

bar comparing the edges and the centre (this should not be the case).

Intex's 1904w performed even worse than the JM1941DF. While calibrating using DisplayMate, we were unable to get many grey blocks on a black background. The purpose of this particular screen is to check the monitors black levels, and contrast ratio. Tuning the monitor to make more invisible grey boxes appear was only possible if we sacrificed background black levels. There were also issues with colour intensity tests—especially for blue. We don't recommend this monitor for gamers, and image editing professionals should avoid this like the plague. However, the price (Rs 11,300) makes it attractive for those working with documents and online content. It is aesthetic enough for an office monitor, and casual home users will be interested to note that many 17-inch monitors cost as much as this one—you're virtually getting 2 inches free!

The ASUS VW192T suffered in the reverse video and reverse text tests—green, yellow and cyan weren't visible on a grey background, and that's not the end of it. There is a contrast ratio problem with the VW192T that's a mile wide, and quite noticeable with colour gradations in movies. This panel also has slightly lower brightness levels due to which the HDR effects in *Oblivion* seemed a little less bloomy than we're used to. This last point however is not really a contrast ratio problem as we mentioned, but a luminance problem—not enough nits (lower Cd/m² spec).

Decision Time

The 19-inch category was closely fought, no quarters taken and none given. AOC took home gold with *Digit's Best Buy Gold Award*—its performance and the brilliant pricing saw it in good stead. The Silver was bagged by the ViewSonic VG921M, as it out-did its widescreen sibling (VA1912W) by some margin. However, take a look at the raw performance scores and you'll see both the 8-bit panels NEC's far ahead in this regard. The MultiSync 1990FX and 1970NXp are the *only* options for discerning professionals with no price constraints.

17-INCH LCDS

The 17-inch LCDs represent the new entry level for anyone looking for flat-panel PC monitors. They've successfully taken over the mantle from the 15-inchers as the face of value in the Indian market.

Decision Maker	
Your Usage	What to Buy
Home, Internet, Basic Multimedia	AOC 177V, VA1703w, AOC 197S
Office Use, Browsing	AOC 177V, AOC 197S, ViewSonic VG921M
Average Gaming	BenQ FP92W, Acer AL1916, BenQ FP71G+
Hardcore/Enthusiast Gamers	ASUS PW201, ASUS MW221u
Design Professionals	NEC MultiSync 1990FX, NEC MultiSync 1970NXp
Multimedia Aficionados	BenQ FP241W, ASUS PW201
Large Screen, aesthetic conscious	Dell E228WFP

HDCP & LCD Monitors

High-Bandwidth Digital Content Protection (HDCP) is a data encrypting system initiated by Intel Corporation and developed by Silicon Image. As the name suggests, HDCP protects digital video and audio content by encryption at every stage of transmission as it moves across digital connects—namely DVI and HDMI—to, ultimately, your screen. This protection is necessary to combat the oldest evil known to digital content—piracy or unauthorised access and duplication.

A PC or a DVD player has to be licensed with HDCP controls before it can play HDCP-protected content. All upcoming standards including Blu-Ray and HD-DVD feature this form of content protection.

What you do need to know is HDCP is built into a few LCD monitors, which you will need to invest in if using such High-Definition content—especially on Windows Vista.

Do also note that when using analog connectivity i.e. D-Sub, it's possible to bypass encryption completely, and display HD content without HDCP. Microsoft has an answer to this—drivers will either constrict resolutions or disable output completely when HDCP content is routed through analog sources instead of digital sources.

The 17-inch LCD is an ideal purchase for home and office users. Better, in fact, than 19-inch monitors if heavy multimedia usage is not your cup of tea. In fact, 17-inch monitors offer the same resolution as 19-inch—1280x1024 and 1440x900 in case of widescreens.

Don't expect to see much of the costlier S-IPS, MVA or PVA panels here—with value taking priority, regular 6-bit TN panels are used. You'll still get 24-bit colour however, courtesy Dithering (see box Are 8-bit Panels Worth It?).

Features? What Are Those?

Any entry level product is mainly focused on pricing, and features are a luxury most manufacturers decided they could do without. As testament to this, none of the 17-inchers sport advanced features like height adjustment and portrait mode. In terms of aspect ratios, ViewSonic's VA1703w was a shocker—the only 17-inch monitor sporting widescreen dimensions. It's compact and offers the same ultra wide 1440x900 pixel resolution that a 19-inch widescreen offers—that's a lot

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AOC 177V
Value Performer